

SECRET INVASION

Trust no one...

ISSUE #1

Once the Avengers finally realize that the Skrulls have infiltrated Earth, Queen Veranke launches the invasion. Sleeper agents around the world awaken, and the destruction begins.

At one time, the SKRULL Empire ruled one of the most powerful interplanetary civilizations in the galaxy. However, a series of wars with the KREE, the destruction of the empire's capital planet by GALACTUS, and the loss of nearly all the empire's other planets to the Annihilation Wave (see pp. 30-1) drove the Skrulls to seek a new home. Because of the interference of humanity over the years—and owing to information the Skrulls gleaned after the ILLUMINATI's botched mission to warn them off—the Skrulls resolved to fulfill an ancient prophecy and lay claim to Earth.

THEY CAME TO CONQUER

The Skrull Queen Veranke began planning the invasion soon after ascending the throne. She began with an initiative to replace powerful and influential defenders of Earth with undetectable sleeper agents. When the AVENGERS discovered that ELEKTRA had been replaced by a Skrull, Tony Stark (IRON MAN) immediately suspected the potential Skrull threat. He called on the Illuminati to come up with a plan to counter an invasion. The other Avengers then learned that a Skrull had replaced BLACK BOLT long ago. Felling that they could not even trust each other, the Super Hero team split to attack the problem on their own.

Realizing that the Avengers knew of the infiltration, Veranke—who had replaced SPIDER-WOMAN—gave the word to launch the invasion. Skrull agents simultaneously attacked several vital people and key points in Earth's defenses. Meanwhile, two teams of Avengers (one sanctioned by the US government and one not) raced to the Savage Land to investigate a crashed Skrull starship. There they faced off against each other and a third group of heroes who claimed to be the originals that the Skrulls had replaced over the years.

Manhattan became the central battleground in the invasion attempt. With the Avengers in the Savage Land, Nick Fury (see FURY, NICK) led a new crew of HOWLING COMMANDOS to help the remaining heroes check the Skrull attacks. Even the HOOD and his villains joined the heroes to fight the Skrulls. As the Hood remarked, "No more Earth is bad for business."

Once Reed Richards (MISTER FANTASTIC) came up with a way to identify the Skrulls, the Avengers raced back to New York and joined the battle there, along with THOR and every other hero in the area. In the course of the battle, Veranke fell, and one of her lieutenants—who had posed as Hank Pym (see PYM, HANK)—activated the growth serum he had given to the WASP back when she thought he was her husband. This caused her to grow to giant size and give off a lethal bio-toxin.

Thor stopped this, but only at the cost of the Wasp's life. Meanwhile, Veranke had recovered, but before she could escape, Norman Osborn (see GREEN GOBLIN) shot her dead. In the aftermath, Tony Stark took much of the blame for not stopping the invasion. The President disbanded SHIELD and replaced it with the Thunderbolts Initiative, placing Norman Osborn in charge of overseeing the USA's registered superhumans. MF



The Skrull who replaced Echo reverted to her natural form after Echo killed her. The fact that one of the Avengers had realized this was a Skrull before told them the untold number of Skrulls who had invaded Earth.



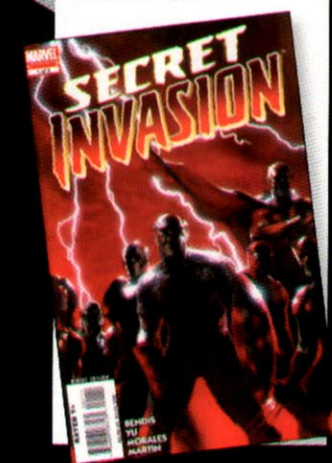
Disasters struck when the Skrulls launched their invasion. The Peak (the orbiting headquarters of SWORD), the SHIELD Helicarrier, the Fantastic Four's Baxter Building, and Thunderbolt Mountain were all destroyed.



When a Skrull infiltrator heard another Skrull say the words, "He loves you," his original personality resurfaced. Until then, the infiltrator was often unaware that he was a Skrull.



Norman Osborn formed a team of villains to help run the world after the Secret Invasion. Besides him, it included Doctor Doom, Loki, the Hood, the Sub-Mariner, and the White Queen.



The climactic conflict happened once Reed Richards had come up with a way to identify the Skrull infiltrators. The heroes of Earth and the invading Skrulls destroyed large chunks of New York City in a pitched battle that shook the streets.